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CENTERPIECE

Documentary to showcase deadly 1926 La Plata tornado

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Elizabeth Wheeler, left, and Danielle Ward fix the hair of Tara Derr, who plays Mrs. Hughes, between takes at the Schoolhouse for a documentary about the deadly tornado that hit La Plata in 1926.

Ilana Williams/Southern Maryland News

Ninety-nine years ago, a devastating tornado blew through La Plata, striking a schoolhouse and killing 13 children.

The weather was much sunnier last weekend when a documentary was filmed at the Port Tobacco One-Room Schoolhouse on the storm's deadly anniversary.

Maryland Motion Pictures and the Port Tobacco Players filmed at the schoolhouse with cast members from the local theater troupe on Nov. 8 and Nov. 9 for the documentary about the Nov. 9, 1926, tornado that struck the La Plata Elementary School.

An initial idea for the documentary was telling individual stories, Steuart Bowling, vice chair of the La Plata Historic Preservation Commission, said. But there were too many names and characters. Now, they are looking at the documentary from a broader perspective.

"Here we are, 100 years later, trying to reconstruct stories that nobody wanted to talk about back then," Bowling said.

When Bowling researched the film, he realized that the newspapers got a lot of the facts wrong, he said.

"It wasn't that the reporters were doing a bad job," he said. "It was that everyone was having a hard time getting a coherent story because everyone was so traumatized."

Historian Tony Puzzilla funded the film production for the "legacy," he said. He and Bowling wrote a book, with hopes for it to be ready by the end of the year, and are in the process of writing a play.

Puzzilla recalled asking Bowling, "Why don't we just go all out?"

The play started the idea for the upcoming movie, Craig Hower, Port Tobacco Players board of directors history/library chair, said. The plan is to show the film during a gala event next fall then air it on Maryland Public Television.

“This is the busiest that the position has been in for some time,” he said. “It’s been very exciting.”

As part of the film, the La Plata Volunteer Fire Department used a hose and airboat to recreate the rain and wind, Bowling said. The tornado “ripped” the school open and pulled some of the children into the funnel.

They reenacted the collapsed roof with special effects and filmed school debris with textbooks, chalk and clothing, Puzzila said.

Bowling said he had two uncles in the school when the tornado hit.

“It’s kind of strange because two of these kids are playing those uncles,” he said. “And one of them was killed in the storm.”

The film shows houses on Oak Avenue and Washington Avenue that belonged to families that were affected by the storm, Bowling said.

Tara Derr, who plays Mrs. Hughes, had never been inside the schoolhouse, she said. She usually works in the orchestra pit at Port Tobacco Players and was asked to do a casting call for the role.

“I’m going with whatever they’re telling me,” she said.

Mrs. Hughes is a 65-year-old woman in the film and was a teacher and the principal of the school, Derr said.

In 1926, the tornado started as a water spout, Bowling said. It ran due north until it went to the outskirts of La Plata before turning east.

Bowling said the film “will be more of a testament to La Plata’s resilience in the face of two really difficult tornados.”
